# The Model Stalinist

By the early 50s, Soviet relations with many Western nations, including the United States, were at their worst levels since the Berlin Blockade, prompting extensive militarisation across the eastern bloc. Moscow was horrified when Washington detonated the first atomic bomb in the Marshall Islands and prepared nuclear war exercises in the Nevada desert. And, as if that wasn't bad enough, the United Nations declared China an aggressor in the Korean War and, at the same time, Stalin accused Britain, the US and France of organising a regular West German army. In response, he sent fresh troops and equipment into East Germany.

Stalin also pushed Ulbricht to form an army, but 'without making much noise, without propaganda. Once the army is already organised, then you can shout about it.'1 Thus, over time, the GDR People's Police became a military force, training in armaments: 'You should have combat police,' Stalin told Ulbricht. 'You should change their instructions, improve their equipment and training.'

From then on, Honecker, too, was urged to reinforce the home front by gearing FDJ members to handle weapons, parachute and learn map reading in order 'to defend the peace'. Starting with the Pioneers, youngsters across the GDR sat through classes featuring anti-Western movies and newsreels. They were given a steady dose of lectures on topics like the 'American enemy', and the 'oppressed and their oppressors'. In addition to a regular solemn flagraising ceremony, they were introduced to lessons celebrating the German 'rebirth' under the banner of socialism.

Over time, Honecker made a pronounced effort to organise special 'shooting games' (target practice) and rifle lessons, while the Children's Hour on GDR national radio, introduced toddlers to the song: We must defend our homeland.2 Propaganda in Junge Welt took on a particularly virulent form by accentuating the peril of foreign threats. 'German youth is ready to defend its Republic,' the paper reported, in summing-up a number